Team 4 Engagement proposal

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Our Chosen Case Study: Grafton South Early Years Centre

Identifying problems

When identifying problems for the Grafton Centre, a key observation was the safe introduction of technology into their operations. Since they care for children's vulnerable data, something like a data leak is a huge issue for the Centre. Another issue that was identified was balancing the amount of technology used in learning, making sure if the children that attend the childcare programs use the technology implemented it is sparingly and not a detriment to their learning, as well as development outside of schooling.

Overall, Grafton South is community focused, wanting to maintain a “child safe and culturally safe” (Swinburne University of Technology, 2026) implementation to their workplace, therefore their input is pivotal to understanding how the learning and development of the kids can be maintained whilst ensuring nothing goes wrong.

Ensuring we get stakeholder responses also helps steer the project in a way that reflects the community using the product. Through regular meetings with stakeholders, the chosen solution can be suited to the needs that Grafton South requires. On top of this, stakeholders can help share their viewpoints. This gives us suggestions on how we can

implement an eco-centric development process, ensuring the environment around Grafton, as well as the broader Australian environment healthy and sustainable.

To make decisions on integrating technology such as for the Early Years Centre, the implementation can also assist our team in filling in areas where our knowledge is not fully developed. Stakeholders can communicate information to us, telling us what the kids struggle with in the current learning system they have, what criteria needs to be met for a technology implementation to be considered successful, and what needs to be done to match the values of indigenous data sovereignty, where Indigenous Australians have the right to govern their own personal information, including creation, deletion and use of data relating to their lands communities and recourses. Ensuring the concerns of stakeholders are implemented into the design we choose in the project is incredibly important to ensure the Grafton South Early Years Centre is happy with the project and aligns with the views of both them and the broader indigenous community.

Stakeholders

The team scouted out stakeholders, identifying various groups impacted or invested in the decisions our technology-based solution would help, solve, and narrow down the list. We were able to narrow down the list of stakeholders to a list of 5, including teachers, families and broader communities, elders, SNAICC, and the kids that could be using said technology.

We identified Kids enrolled in the Early Years Centre as a priority stakeholder as they will potentially be using the product developed as part of their daily experiences learning at the Youth Centre, therefore they are considered the top priority for who we center the apps development around and make the core focus of the project. We also identified Centre staff and support workers as priority stakeholders as they will be using this product to educate children and deepen their bond to country, an equally important role that makes them very high-priority stakeholders. Both stakeholders have an incredibly high impact and will have similar preferences for how the service is used. Kids could participate in feedback through assemblies where they can raise their hands and give feedback as a group, whereas meetings with teachers could be coordinated to efficiently develop ideas and make sure everyone is able to attend, corresponding with the right time and right place of the five pillars

We also identified Elders as well as Parents and the broader community as relevant priority stakeholders, as guardians and role models for the kids in the Youth Centre, therefore their opinions on the technology and how it should be implemented are very important to shape how the kids develop and grow. Elders carry a high level of respect in the community,

therefore guidance from elders on how a technology-based project should be implemented would assist greatly in our project development. Parents are also a priority stakeholder as they are the ones sending their children to the Centre, and would be very invested in their child's development, therefore the project needs to be designed with these concerns in mind and make sure that they aren't displeased with the overall project. There could be conflicts in decision making processes as kids could have different outlooks on how much technology should be directly placed in their learning compared to the parents who could be worried that too much technology could be a detriment to their health. Yarning with elders could be a way to share ideas in the right way, and conversations with families and communities using the right language can help us identify the correct way to implement the program at the Centre.

The final priority stakeholder we identified was SNAICC, the governing body that has a strong interest in the work the Grafton South Centre does and would have a strong interest in our project and what it can accomplish. SNAICC describes their initiative as “playing a central role in shaping policy, practice and reform at a national level.” (SNAICC, 2026) Including a professional stakeholder can give our group key insights into how to effectively develop the product our team makes and assist with making it an accommodating product for all to use. A professional meeting would be the right way to communicate as it would be a professional setting, and ensuring we use the right language is important to make sure no misunderstandings are made. Conflicts with the other stakeholders are likely minimal as SNAICC would like to see the Centre succeed, however there is a chance that parents, elders and the overall community don't like the stance SNAICC gives on the project and its direction.

Context and supporting literature

The Grafton South Early Years Centre is a concerted effort; therefore, it is important to understand the context of the issue and how our team can come up with a solution. The primary objective of the Early Years Centre is to “support families connected to Gummyaney” (Absec, 2026) so making an application that strengthens the connection to indigenous heritage is a must.

Through the research our group has completed for the engagement proposal, our group has developed insights on the people involved and interested in the project, and how stakeholders should be engaged with the development as “active stakeholder engagement is very important for all kinds of businesses in markets across the world” (Anastasi, 2018) and can be carried over to the development of our project in the same way.

The stakeholders can provide us with various information on their community, ensuring we can learn how we can “recognize, protect and advance the inherent rights, cultures and traditions” (Safework NSW) and apply this to the culture and traditions of not only Grafton, but Indigenous traditions.

Many of our stakeholders are also deeply connected with the culture of the local area and have a large understanding of indigenous governance and how it can be implemented into our project, as it is important for “the strength of communities as a whole.” (AIGI)

The perspectives of the stakeholders can help us guide the project in a positive way and make a product more fitting for the people in the Early Years Centre. From our research, we needed to consider the different views of our stakeholders, which “may differ and conflict with other stakeholders.” (PMI)

We needed to research how to safely and efficiently integrate, requiring considerations of the relevant technology. Our research helped us recognize that while we are working in a specific area, we should add “scale and evolve” (9yards) should the project need to ensure that our project is well thought out and has very few flaws in its design.

Application to Key Frameworks

For our endeavor to work out successfully we need to "introduce the concepts of Two-Eyed Seeing and the Five Rights, which emphasize respectful collaboration, Indigenous leadership, cultural safety, and the protection of Indigenous knowledge and data." (Swinburne University Of Technology, 2026)

We understand the need to have epistemic humility while building relationships with our stakeholders and focusing on developing sustainable products that fit their needs. We acknowledge that there exists a significant gap between the ideas of the development team and the perspective of the community. We hope to bridge this gap by framing our approach using Five Pillars and Five Rights.

1. **Right People**:

We have designed and ordered a list of stakeholders with whom we would collect data for our project. These high-priority stakeholders include Elders as well as Parents and the broader community (including educators and staff), SNAICC. Our other stakeholders (not from the community) include Local ACCO, NSW Department of education, and other professionals who have knowledge working with indigenous projects.

Connection to Five pillars:

- **Country**: Consulting Elders, family and community honours their authority to speak for land and ensures decisions respect its cultural and spiritual significance.
- **Kinship**: Engaging with these stakeholders we could collect relevant information while they could represent and server as a guiding voice.
- **Culture**: As they are the holders of cultural and environmental knowledge, which is critical for projects impacting Country.
- **Journey**: We acknowledge historical and ongoing experiences of the community, ensuring processes contribute positively.
- **Connectedness**: Working with these Stakeholder is beneficial to our development process as well as it ensures trust, collaboration, and strong relationships with the community.

2. **Right Place**:

We understand the need to have locations that respect cultural protocols and provide a safe, appropriate environment for dialogue. We ensure this by setting meetings and study groups at places from a list of right places approved by the right people to represent the community, Elders, staff, and SNAICC.

Reflection on the Five Pillars:

- **Country**: Holding meetings on these communal places acknowledge its spiritual and cultural significance.
- **Kinship**: Choosing these spaces where family and community networks can participate supports decision-making and respects their time.
- **Culture**: Respecting protocols about where certain conversations occur can safeguard cultural integrity and sometimes teach us more about the culture.
- **Journey**: This would go long way to prove that we are working more mutual gains
- **Connectedness**: Meeting in culturally safe environments strengthens relationships and collaboration between different stakeholders.

3. **Right Language**

Any ideas, concerns or comments on the work should be addressed in the right language. We would make efforts to speak in a simple, understanding format without any technical terms to keep the stakeholders in our discussions. We also recognize the importance of

Aboriginal language and therefore assigning Experts in local Gumbaynggirr language integration in our meetings. We would also follow AIATSIS terminology guide for culturally appropriate language.

Connection to Five pillars:

- **Country**: Right Language respects the stakeholder's land and its cultural significance.
- **Kinship**: Communication would honor cultural protocols, and addresses people appropriately.
- **Culture**: Using culturally safe language preserves traditions and avoids misinterpretation.
- **Journey**: It would greatly impact the speed and approval of the project.
- **Connectedness**: Clear, respectful language strengthens relationships and trust.

4. **Right Time**

We understand the need to respect cultural obligations, seasonal activities, and community priorities. Therefore, the time for meetings, studies, and surveys would be conducted aligned to the community calendar. There would be a checklist instead of a fixed deadline. We would ask for suitable dates and Avoid scheduling during Sorry Business or cultural ceremonies.

Relations to Five Pillars:

- **Country**: Respect for Seasonal cycles and land-based activities.
- **Kinship**: Family obligations and community events shape timing.
- **Culture**: Ceremonies and cultural practices dictate when engagement is appropriate.
- **Journey**: Every scheduling would include the stakeholders throughout the completion of the project.
- **Connectedness**: Aligning project timelines with community would strengthen collaboration.

5. **Right way**

We would conduct meetings and construct our project in a respectful way for the shareholders. Right way is about how you approach consultation, decision-making, and collaboration and not just what you do. How can you get in contact with the person without

disrespecting the community of elders or the other members and organizations. We would follow cultural protocols such as Welcome to Country and permission seeking. We would be transparent and share information openly and explain how decisions will be made. Our approach includes:

Families and community	Child educators'/support staff	Elders	SNAICC	Kids in early youth center
Have the kids take a letter to their parents so that you can set a meeting with the families in the community	Send an email to the child educators and the support staff for a meeting to discuss new technology	Approach the people of the Grafton community so that you can set up a meeting with the elders	Contact the origination Member through their services and contact numbers so that you can setup a meeting with the representative member	Assembly for kids in center

Connection to Five Pillars:

- **Country**: Respecting cultural protocols when working on Country through permission, ceremonies.
- **Kinship**: Following norms when engaging with Elders and families.
- **Culture**: Honoring traditions and practices in consultation and decision-making.
- **Journey**: Recognizing historical experiences and ensuring processes supporting healing and empowerment.
- **Connectedness**: Building genuine partnerships through culturally respectful methods.

Data management, Governance, and cyber security considerations

To implement technology into this scenario, our team will potentially deal with several types of information relating to children, families, and Centre operations, which includes the children's enrolment, their attendance, and learning and development information. (Office of the Australian Information Commissioner, 2026). There are also parent or guardian contact details, emergency contacts, family support information, and referrals to health or community services. As some of the information is sensitive, especially information relating to children's health or family circumstances, the Australian Privacy Principles (APPs) require organizations to manage personal information appropriately and

only collect information that is reasonably necessary for their functions. Meaning, the solution should apply data minimization, ensuring that only information required for an identified purpose is collected.
Each type of information should also have a clear purpose, for example the attendance data may support administration, while the learning and development information could help the educators in supporting children's needs. Family contact information may be required for communication, while referral information may support authorized connections with health and community services. Information should not be collected simply because it may be useful in the future, as clear purposes also allow families and staff to understand how their information is being used. (Office of the Australian Information Commissioner, 2026)

Discuss the information managed by the system, in terms of types, storage considerations, privacy, user responsibilities, and protections.

An important consideration in exploring technology opportunities for the Grafton South Aboriginal Early Years Centre is how the information will be managed, protected, and governed. As the Centre works closely with many children, family, staff, and community members, the information provided may include personal, sensitive, and culturally significant data that requires appropriate protection. This means that our solutions must have data practices supporting both privacy and security, while also respecting the Aboriginal community's control and cultural authority. Alongside these considerations, any future technology should be practical, sustainable, and appropriate for the Centre's organizational context. These factors are important in being able to ensure that the proposed technology can support the Centre's responsibilities to the children, families, and community while also maintaining culturally safe and ethical practices.

Information should be stored using secure systems that protect against loss, unauthorized access, modification, and disclosure. Depending on the final solution, this should include appropriate authentication, encryption, secure backups and access control. The access to this should be determined by a user's role and responsibilities. An example of this is the educators potentially needing information relevant to the students' learning and care, while visiting professionals should only be able to access the information necessary for their authorized role. The staff should use individual accounts, secure passwords, and multi-factor authentication where they can. They should also receive some minor cybersecurity training and understand how to identify and report potential security incidents (Australian Children's Education & Care Quality Authority, 2024). These additions reduce the likelihood of accidental or unauthorized disclosure or leaks of children's and

families' information. (Office of the Australian Information Commissioner, 2026) (Australian Children's Education & Care Quality Authority, 2024)

Data governance needs to extend past technical security and should consider who has the authority over the information. This is important for the Grafton South Aboriginal Early Years Centre because it operates within an Aboriginal community-controlled context. Indigenous Data Sovereignty recognizes Indigenous peoples' rights and interests in determining how information about Indigenous peoples and communities is collected, managed, and used (Kukutai, T., & Taylor, J. (Eds.), 2016). The CARE Principles (Collective Benefit, Authority to control, Responsibilities and Ethics) emphasize indigenous authority and community benefit in data practices (Carroll, 2020). Alongside this, decisions about accessing, sharing, retaining or reusing community-related information should align with the Centre's governance structures and cultural protocols. Cultural knowledge should receive consideration and should not be automatically treated as ordinary organizational data. Appropriate cultural authority should determine whether such information can be collected, stored, or shared. This supports the Centre's existing emphasis on community control and Indigenous data sovereignty.

Design decisions, sustainability, and tradeoffs

These data requirements should influence the design of the proposed technology and its future roadmap as the solution should be secure, accessible, and straightforward for staff and families to use, while fitting within the Centre's existing practices. Sustainability should consider ongoing licensing, maintenance, training, hardware, and technical support costs. The design should also avoid creating unnecessary dependence on a technology provider or placing excessive administrative demands on staff. There will be trade-offs between things such as security and convenience, cost and functionality, and digital access and inclusion. An example of this is having stronger security measures creating additional steps for use, while relying heavily on digital communication could create barriers for families with limited connectivity or those with a lack of digital confidence. These trade-offs should be considered alongside the Centre's cultural and community priorities, as technology should support existing relationships and culturally safe practices, rather than attempting to replace important face-to-face engagement.

The best engagement approach

Prior to engagement with our stakeholder, the group has determined that finding the right people in the community is most important so that they can provide us with their cultural knowledge and guidance about community priorities. For example, our team discussed communicating with the centre's Aboriginal governance and staff to help identify the right people to participate in the meeting so that we don't make assumptions about who best represents the Community we are trying to reach.

The first stage of the engagement should be focused on building relationships, understanding community priorities, and determining how stakeholders want the engagement process to operate, and after both parties agree on how, when, and where both our team and stakeholders wish to have the meeting.

When we are communicating with the stakeholders, we should use clear, respectful, and culturally appropriate language so that the stakeholders don't feel disrespected. When our group coordinates a meeting with the stakeholders, there should be straightforward examples and demonstrations of what the technology will look like so that the stakeholders can guide us on appropriate cultural knowledge and communication protocols, particularly when discussing cultural knowledge or community information.

The stakeholder should then help the team select a respectful and accessible location for engagement. This could be the Grafton South Early Years Centre or another community location that stakeholders might consider comfortable and respectful.

Depending on stakeholder preferences, engagement could occur through:

- face-to-face meetings
- surveys
- email
- video meetings
- other communication methods suggested by the stakeholders.

This encourages easy and open conversation so stakeholders can participate comfortably.

Then the team will start to gather information that will help us develop the technology so that the stakeholders are directly involved when the findings are validated and before technology recommendations are made. If we make the technology first, it would be harder for us to make changes retroactively, thereby limiting the stakeholder ability to influence the decision on what's good for the community.

In this information gathering session we will ask stakeholders about:

- what they need the technology to achieve

- What they think about the current cultural learning that is currently supported
- what information needs to be protected
- problems experienced with current technology
- areas where technology could improve services
- cultural requirements that need to be considered
- privacy requirements for children and families
- how cultural knowledge should be handled and protected.

Their participation allows community priorities to shape the requirements that technology will need to meet their standards. So that we can then develop the technology based on what the stakeholders provide from the information gathering.

In this, we can also identify cultural requirements, including privacy and protection of children's and families' information, and how one should handle all of the cultural knowledge so that our team can respect the cultural heritage; this way, the stakeholders can identify any situations where technology is not respectful of cultural heritage and is damaging it. This way, make sure that all the stakeholders will influence what the clear outcome of the technology will be.

When we have gathered all the information needed from the stakeholder in the meetings, we can then begin the process of validating the data collected. When it begins, we then need to meet with the stakeholder and get a clear summary of what was discussed in the meetings and whether the documented requirements accurately meet their views, community priorities, cultural requirements, privacy requirements and technology needs.

This way, if there are any misunderstandings and/or missing requirements, cultural misinformation, or if they need any change in priorities. it can be resolved so that we can meet the stakeholder requirements and provide the best possible technology service for the Grafton South Early Years Centre.

this engagement approach ensures that the technology developed for the Grafton South Early Years Centre is based on community priorities, stakeholder knowledge and agreed requirements. It also supports respectful engagement, cultural safety, participation from stakeholders, privacy of children's and families.

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